

ference between what Siegel patched together, touched up with conciliatory, politically-correct solutions from the author, and the parts that are authentically Benazir's. If the book has any value, it is the second stream.

It is not that Benazir lies consciously about her record. No politician can be expected to dwell on missed opportunity, compromise or failure, and Benazir does not mention the fact that she did nothing about the discriminatory Hudood laws when she was prime minister, or that she was the principal benefactor of the Taliban. Fatima, Benazir's niece, believes that Asif Zardari ordered the murder of Murtaza Bhutto, Benazir's brother, and her father.

There is an element of fantasy in Benazir's view of her past, and more than a trace of the unreal in her assessment of the future. She is so deeply imbued with a sense of self-righteousness that she can do no wrong, or ever be wrong. It is possible that she did not realise how much Pakistan had changed during her years away from her country, or the extent to which terrorists had become part of the anonymous heartland. She thought that she would sweep the polls in every corner of the country. But even her death could not generate sufficient sympathy to take her tally of seats much beyond Sind. The alibi being trotted out, of rigging, is not convincing. The simple fact is that the third player, Sharif, held the trumps in Punjab.

The most moving passages are Benazir's descriptions of danger, and the extraordinary challenge that she decided to take up. She was a patriot, who believed that it was her destiny to heal the lacerating wounds that are bleeding Pakistan. The details of conspiracy and threat do not really matter, even when she is all too eager to pass off hearsay as fact. But the danger to her life was real, and she knew that she was the target of an array of ruthless enemies. She all but accuses Musharraf of complicity in the first attempt on her life, in Karachi; in her mind, the alliance with Musharraf was only the semi-final stage of her return to power. Whatever her flaws, it is undeniable that Benazir was a woman of substance, a leader of charisma and courage. *Reconciliation* is testimony to her extraordinary qualities. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	A Thousand Splendid Suns	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
2. (4)	The Kite Runner	Khaled Hosseini	Penguin
3. (9)	Shantaram	Gregory David Roberts	Little Brown
4. (5)	The Alchemist	Paulo Coelho	HarperCollins
5. (2)	Playing for Pizza	John Grisham	Random House

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (-)	The Monk Who Sold His Ferrari	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico
3. (4)	We Are Like That Only: Understanding the Logic of Consumer India	Rama Bijapurkar	Penguin
4. (2)	The Age of Turbulence	Alan Greenspan	Penguin
5. (8)	Maximum City: Bombay Lost and Found	Suketu Mehta	Penguin

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (-)	Chowringhee	Shankar	Penguin
7. (8)	Animal's People	Indra Sinha	Penguin
9. (3)	The Inheritance of Loss	Kiran Desai	Penguin
10. (-)	Buddha: A Story of Enlightenment	Deepak Chopra	HarperCollins
13. (-)	The Age of Shiva	Manil Suri	Bloomsbury

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (5)	The Elephant, the Tiger and the Cellphone: Reflections on India in the 21st Century	Shashi Tharoor	Penguin
8. (13)	Daily Inspiration	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico
12. (3)	In Spite of The Gods: The Strange Rise of Modern India	Edward Luce	Little Brown

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead